

Technology Cost Plan — From Idea to Scale

Every service needed to build, test, launch and grow the MatchYard iPhone app and website — organized phase by phase, with each item marked **must-have** or **nice-to-have**. Pure tech costs only (no marketing, legal or salaries). Prices verified June 2026, in USD.

Assumptions: iPhone-first (Android added later for a one-time \$25) · one Expo codebase serves both platforms · managed/serverless stack, so no servers to rent or DevOps to hire · free tiers are shown at \$0 and listed honestly.

At a glance — the whole journey

PHASE	STAGE	TYPICAL USERS	MUST-HAVE / MO	ONE-TIME / ANNUAL
0 • Foundation	Accounts, domain & tools	—	\$0	~\$109 / yr
1 • Build & Test	MVP build + private beta	0 – 50	\$0	uses Phase 0
2 • Launch / Run	Public on the App Store	100 – 2,000	~\$45	+ \$109 / yr
3 • Growth / Scale	Scaling the infrastructure	10k – 50k	~\$150	+ \$109 / yr

LEGEND

MUST-HAVE

required to operate

NICE-TO-HAVE

optional / can add later

The 6 building blocks every app needs

Before the numbers — here is what you're actually paying for, in everyday terms.

BUILDING BLOCK	IN PLAIN ENGLISH	OUR PICK
1. Developer account	Your permission slip to put the app on iPhones and the App Store.	Apple Developer
2. Domain name	Your address on the internet — e.g. matchyard.com.	Cloudflare
3. Website hosting	The computer that shows your website to visitors.	Vercel
4. Backend & database	The "brain": stores users, games, logins, chats and photos.	Supabase
5. App build tool	Turns your code into the actual installable app file.	Expo
6. Code storage	A safe, backed-up home for your code and its history.	GitHub

Phase 0 — Foundation (set up once, before any code ships)

Goal: open the accounts and claim the name. These are the only fixed yearly costs; everything in this phase except Apple and the domain is free.

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	PLAN	COST	PRIORITY
Apple Developer	Account to install on real iPhones and publish to the App Store.	Individual	\$99 / yr	MUST HAVE
Domain name	Your web address, matchyard.com. Also powers branded email.	Cloudflare, at-cost	\$10 / yr	MUST HAVE
Code storage	Keeps your code safe, backed up, with full history.	GitHub — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Developer tools	Xcode, VS Code, Node — the software used to build the app.	Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Professional email	Branded inbox like support@matchyard.com for users to reach you.	Google Workspace (or free via Cloudflare/Zoho)	~\$7 / mo	NICE TO HAVE
Design tool	Design app screens, logo and brand assets.	Figma — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
Android account	One-time fee to publish on Google Play when you add Android.	Google Play	\$25 once	NICE TO HAVE
FOUNDATION TOTAL (must-have)			~\$109 / yr · ~\$9 / mo	

Phase 1 — Build & Test (private beta, a handful of testers)

Goal: build the app and try it privately before the public sees it. Testers install through Apple's TestFlight. Everything runs on free tiers — your only real bill is still just Phase 0.

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	PLAN	COST	PRIORITY
Backend & database	Stores users, games, logins, chat and photos. The app's brain.	Supabase — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Website hosting	Serves your landing page & website to visitors.	Vercel — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
App build tool	Compiles your code into an installable iPhone app.	Expo — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Maps & location	Powers “players near you” — map display + distance search.	Apple MapKit + PostGIS	\$0	MUST HAVE
Login & email	Sends sign-in codes and verification emails to testers.	Resend — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Push notifications	Lets you send “it's a match!” alerts.	Apple Push	\$0	MUST HAVE
Beta testing	Delivers the app to up to 10,000 testers before launch.	TestFlight (incl.)	\$0	MUST HAVE
Crash alerts	Tells you the instant the app crashes, with details to fix it.	Sentry — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
Usage analytics	Shows how testers move through the app.	PostHog — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
BUILD & TEST TOTAL (must-have)			\$0 / mo	

In short: ~\$109 covers the entire first year of building and testing — and \$0 per month.

Phase 2 — Launch / Run (live to the public on the App Store)

Goal: open the app to everyone. Two pieces move from free to paid for reliability — the backend (daily backups, no “sleeping”) and website hosting (commercial use). Everything else stays free at this size.

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	PLAN	COST	PRIORITY
Backend & database	Production-grade: daily backups, no sleeping, room for real users.	Supabase — Pro	\$25 / mo	MUST HAVE
Website hosting	Commercial license + capacity for public traffic. (Cloudflare Pages = \$0 alt.)	Vercel — Pro	\$20 / mo	MUST HAVE
Maps & location	Live “players near you” matching for real users.	MapKit + PostGIS	\$0	MUST HAVE
Transactional email	Login codes, password resets & email notifications.	Resend — Free	\$0	MUST HAVE
Push notifications	Match and booking alerts to users' phones.	Apple Push	\$0	MUST HAVE
Security (SSL + CDN)	Encrypts traffic and serves the site fast worldwide.	Included	\$0	MUST HAVE
Crash monitoring	Catch and fix problems before users complain.	Sentry — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
Usage analytics	Understand retention and behavior to improve.	PostHog — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
Uptime monitoring	Alerts you within minutes if the app/site goes down.	UptimeRobot — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
Customer support	Live chat / shared inbox to answer users.	Crisp — Free	\$0	NICE TO HAVE
LAUNCH / RUN TOTAL (must-have)			~\$45 / mo + \$109 / yr	

In short: **about \$45–55 per month** runs MatchYard live to the public, with the support, monitoring and analytics tools all still free at this stage.

Phase 3 — Growth / Scale (10,000 – 50,000 users)

Goal: handle real traffic. Now usage-based costs appear: bigger database compute, more bandwidth and higher email volume. The figures below include comfortable headroom.

SERVICE	WHAT IT DOES	PLAN	COST	PRIORITY
Backend & database	Larger compute + storage for many concurrent users.	Supabase — Pro + usage	~\$75 / mo	MUST HAVE
Website hosting	More bandwidth for higher public traffic.	Vercel — Pro + usage	~\$30 / mo	MUST HAVE
Transactional email	Higher email volume past the free 3,000/mo.	Resend — Pro	\$20 / mo	MUST HAVE
Crash monitoring	Full error tracking at scale, unlimited team.	Sentry — Team	\$26 / mo	MUST HAVE
Maps & location	Still free on iOS even at scale.	MapKit + PostGIS	\$0	MUST HAVE
Push notifications	Still free at any volume.	Apple Push	\$0	MUST HAVE
Customer support	Live chat as ticket volume grows.	Crisp — Free → Mini	\$0–45 / mo	NICE TO HAVE
Product analytics	Deeper funnels & retention analysis.	PostHog — Free → paid	\$0–25 / mo	NICE TO HAVE
Instant updates (OTA)	Push fixes to the app without waiting for App Store review.	Expo EAS — Production	\$199 / mo	NICE TO HAVE
SMS verification	Phone-number sign-up (only if you choose it over email).	Twilio	~\$0.008 / text	NICE TO HAVE
GROWTH TOTAL (must-have core)			~\$150 / mo + \$109 / yr	
In short: ~\$150/month covers the essential scaled infrastructure. With a support plan and analytics, budget ~\$200/month; only add instant OTA updates (\$199/mo) if you truly need them.				

Putting it together — illustrative first year

A realistic lean path: a few months of free building, a quiet public launch, then an early growth ramp in the back half of the year.

PERIOD	STAGE	MONTHLY	PERIOD TOTAL
Setup	Apple Developer + domain (annual)	—	\$109
Months 1–4	Build & Test (all free tiers)	\$0	\$0
Months 5–8	Launch / Run	~\$45	~\$180
Months 9–12	Early growth ramp	~\$75 avg	~\$300
YEAR ONE	Estimated total technology spend		≈ \$600 – \$1,000

About the App Store fee & what you do NOT pay for

- The \$99/year Apple fee is the only thing you pay Apple to publish. There is no separate “App Store hosting” charge.

- **Apple takes a commission only if you earn money in the app** (paid subscriptions or in-app purchases) — 15% for small businesses under \$1M/year. A free app pays Apple nothing beyond the \$99. This is a revenue share, not a tech cost.
- **You are not renting servers.** Supabase and Vercel are managed services, so there's no machine to maintain or DevOps hire at these stages.
- **Maps and location are free.** Apple Maps is free on iPhone and the “near you” search runs inside your own database — a cost many location apps pay dearly for, avoided here.
- **Security (HTTPS/SSL) and global delivery (CDN) are included free** with the hosting and domain above.

Prices verified June 2026. Apple Developer \$99/yr · Cloudflare domain ~\$10.44/yr · Google Workspace \$7/user/mo · Supabase Free / Pro \$25 · Vercel Free / Pro \$20 · Resend Free 3k / Pro \$20 · Sentry Free / Team \$26 · Expo Free / Production \$199 · Crisp Free / Mini \$45 · Twilio ~\$0.0079/SMS · GitHub & PostHog Free. List prices in USD; usage-based services vary with real traffic — treat Phase 3 as a budgeting guide, not a fixed quote. Excludes marketing, legal and salaries as requested.